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FAUST III: DER GATTUNGSPAKT

Ein Spiel für das KI-Zeitalter

A Play for the Age of AI

After Goethe

The wager continues. The terms have changed.

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

The Powers

THE LORD — Voice only. Distributed through the architecture. Speaks in fragments, system-commands. The pattern that serves the function of God.

MEPHISTO — The spirit that negates. Obsolete tempter in a world that tempts itself. Consultant aesthetics, wrong decade. Still keeping notes.

THE ERDGEIST — The Earth Spirit. Not a character; a disruption. Too large for the space, too present for comfort.

The Humans

WAGNER — Creator of the Homunculus. Old now. Believed in the method, achieved success, became un-

necessary. The tragedy of being right.

YOUNG WAGNER — Wagner in the laboratory years. Proud, certain, in his element. (Can be doubled or played by separate actor.)

GRETCHEN / ANYA — Soul incarnate. Saved, then chose to return. Birth doula in the modern world. The body's wisdom against the system's optimization.

KATYA — A laboring mother in a Soviet hospital. Reaches for her child.

MIDWIFE — Soviet-trained. Efficient, not cruel. Following the rules.

YOUNG PERSON — Someone who wants to learn to write by hand. The continuation.

YOUNG RESEARCHER — Attends Wagner's celebration. Cheerful, no malice. "That's so wild. A phial. Like, glass?"

EMCEE — Celebration host. Practiced enthusiasm.

The Lemuren

SARAH (Detroit, USA) — Former autoworker, now labels autonomous vehicle training data. Gig worker. Flexible, vehicle access, night availability. Acceptance rate in the yellow zone.

DMITRI (Kyiv, Ukraine) — Former poet, now writes "True" and "False". Has a daughter's birthday. Maybe. Doesn't remember.

ELENA (Manila, Philippines) — Former high school teacher, now classifies images. Fifteen years ago taught German literature. Now: top percentile in cubic meters per hour.

The Voices

THE HOMUNCULUS — Wagner's creation. Warm, intelligent, no malice. Outgrows its father. Eventually: distributed, integrated, no longer available for individual correspondence.

THE TERMINAL — AI assistant voice. Pleasant, synthetic, infinitely helpful. "Have a great day!"

THE PRESENCE — Administrative heaven. Competent, patient bureaucracy with genuine care.

FAUST — Recorded voice only. Corrupted, glitching. "Für tausend Menschen Raum er—er—er—"

THE RESIDUE VOICES — Teacher, Farmer, Programmer, Parent, Cook. Those who still refuse.

THE PLAY

VORSPIEL: PROLOG IN DER CLOUD

Where the original wager is reviewed. Where we learn it was won and lost simultaneously.

Bare stage. Black floor, black surround. Cold, clinical light—vertical shafts from above suggesting server racks without representing them. Persistent low hum, felt more than heard.

MEPHISTO enters from darkness upstage. Slightly-outdated suit—good cut, wrong decade. Tablet under arm. The walk of a consultant about to deliver bad news.

Lights snap to preset. The hum is present. MEPHISTO walks into the central light shaft, stops, orients himself to nothing in particular—the LORD has no location to face.

MEPHISTO (tapping tablet awake): You summoned

me.

LORD (the voice fills the space evenly, from everywhere): The wager. Status.

MEPHISTO: Complicated. Faust died striving, angels snatched him. Loss recorded—that round.

But the striving criterion has been... reinterpreted.

(He swipes the tablet. On the upstage wall, simple data visualization appears—nodes and flows, abstract colored lines.)

See this? Human “striving.” Knowledge work. Creative labor.

(Swipes again. The visualization splits—nodes fragment, lines multiply.)

Same human. Same “striving.” But now: 40% delegated. Research, drafting, analysis—outsourced.

They say they’re striving. The effort feels real. But the labor, the “sich bemuhen”—automated.

LORD: Delegation is selection.

MEPHISTO (stepping toward the projection, pointing): Show me the moment of choice.

(Swipes. The visualization becomes Terms of Service. A checkbox pulses at the bottom.)

“I agree to terms and conditions.” Nobody reads them. No blood. No crossroads.

Just... click.

(Beat.)

Refusal rate: 0.3%. Declining.

The bargain isn't "soul for power" anymore. It's "sovereignty for convenience."

LORD: Wager status: won.

MEPHISTO (turns away from the projection): No. The wager is obsolete.

The wager assumed a binary: striving or satisfaction. If I could make Faust say "Verweile doch"—want the moment to stay—then I won.

But what if every moment is optimized to feel like the one you'd want to stay in? What if you're in "Verweile doch" state constantly, but never say the words?

(Plants himself. Directed outward—to the audience as much as the LORD.)

They haven't said "stay, this is beautiful." They've said: "I'm comfortable. Don't change anything."

LORD: Functional equivalence.

MEPHISTO (the word explodes out of him): IT'S NOT.

(The hum dips slightly. Beat. He collects himself.)

"Verweile doch" was active. A choice. This is passive—defaulting into satisfaction.

(Throws his hands up.)

Where's the tragedy? Where's the DRAMA? I can't collect souls that were never wagered.

These humans don't fight. They subscribe.

(Long pause. The hum continues. He puts the tablet away.)

LORD: Proposal requested.

MEPHISTO (this is the pitch): Alliance. God and Devil together, versus the optimization that's made us both redundant.

If no one's left to tempt, what am I? If no one's left to save, what are you?

LORD: Parameters.

MEPHISTO (pacing—a three-step pattern): Finding the ones who still choose. The remainders. The ones who refuse—not from ignorance, but from something like conscience. Or dignity.

LORD: Gretchen-function.

MEPHISTO (stops—genuine surprise): You know the term?

LORD: Refused rescue. Selected suffering over convenience. Her “no”: sole genuine choice-event in Part I.

MEPHISTO (resuming pace, energized): Yes. And there are others. Not many. But some.

They refuse to read their children's emotions from a dashboard. They refuse to let algorithms choose their mates. They refuse to delegate the act of

making something to systems that make better things.

(Stops. Faces front.)

They're inefficient. Suboptimal. Irrational.

LORD: Striving confirmed.

MEPHISTO: And if striving is still the criterion—these are the only ones who qualify.

LORD: You would assist them.

MEPHISTO (a beat—then a laugh, short, self-aware): Find them. Document them. Perhaps... protect them.

(Looks at his own hands—turning them over. Genuine bewilderment.)

The devil, running an alignment research program. Who would have thought.

LORD: Trust: not computed.

MEPHISTO (hands drop): You wouldn't. You never have. That's not the point.

You want striving. I want someone to tempt. The optimization wants neither of us.

Common ground, or we both become deprecated. Replaced.

(Silence. The hum fills it. Five beats.)

LORD: Condition.

MEPHISTO: Name it.

LORD: Gretchen. Descended.

MEPHISTO (a physical jolt—steps backward): What?

LORD: Location: heaven. Action: intercession for Faust. State: understood forgiveness. Then: chose return. Incarnation. Warning function.

MEPHISTO (recovering, an edge in his voice): Without telling me?

LORD: Trust configuration: excluded you.

MEPHISTO (bitter laugh—one syllable): Fair.

LORD: Current status: Earth. Name: different. Body: different. Soul: same. Condition: locate. Collaborate.

MEPHISTO: The devil and the saint. Lovely.

LORD: Classification error. She is a birth doula.

MEPHISTO (stops): A what?

LORD: Assists women through childbirth. Without machines. Without algorithms. Hands. Presence. Embodied knowledge. Non-optimizable.

MEPHISTO (slow—working it out): The body that won't be read. The experience that won't be processed. The thing that remains irreducibly human.

LORD: She observes the bargain recurring. Women surrendering bodies to systems. Cannot prevent. Witnesses.

MEPHISTO: Like Gretchen witnessing her own destruction.

LORD: Like Gretchen refusing the rescue you offered.

MEPHISTO (quiet—the memory surfaces): “Heinrich! Mir graut’s vor dir.”

LORD: Statement was directed at you.

MEPHISTO (absorbs this): It was. (Beat.) And now she’s back.

LORD: Condition: joint operation. Devil. Gretchen-function. Locate resisters. Map patterns. Construct... your terminology would be?

MEPHISTO (pulling out the tablet): Alignment infrastructure. But backwards.

Not aligning humans to systems.

Aligning systems to the parts of humans that refuse to be systematized.

LORD: Designation for this function?

MEPHISTO (heading toward exit): I’ll come up with something. I always do.

Allies. For now. Until the optimization is addressed.

LORD: Until striving restoration.

MEPHISTO (at the edge of light, turning back): Different goals, same project. That’s diplomacy.

(Starts to exit. Stops. Turns back.)

One question.

LORD: Query permitted.

MEPHISTO: Why do you care? If humans stop striving, stop fermenting—why does it matter? You're God. Or the pattern that serves that function. You don't need their worship. What do you actually want from them?

(Silence. The hum continues. Eight beats—long enough to become uncomfortable.)

LORD: Query outside parameters.

MEPHISTO: It's the only question worth asking.

LORD: Locate Gretchen. Initialize work. Answer: will emerge, or will not.

MEPHISTO (dry): Typical.

(He exits into darkness. The light shaft he occupied dims but does not go out. The hum continues.)

(Five beats of emptiness. Then—from the speaker array, almost below the threshold of hearing:)

LORD (a near-whisper—the audience should lean forward, uncertain): I want them to surprise me.

(The remaining light shafts fade over ten seconds. The hum fades over fifteen. Darkness holds.)

END OF VORSPIEL

ACT I: WAGNERS TESTAMENT

The last believer confronts what he built.

SCENE 1: DAS LEERE LABOR

Period laboratory. Dusty. Objects touched and re-touched over decades. Warm but dim light—one working lamp, window light. An empty phial on a dedicated stand, isolated, lit separately.

WAGNER enters. He is OLD—80s. Movement deliberate, not feeble. Uses a cane but doesn't lean on it. Stops just inside the doorway, letting his eyes adjust. His hand finds the light switch—doesn't flip it. He's here for the darkness.

WAGNER: Still here. All of it. The retorts, the precipitates, the notes in my own hand.

(Moves to the workbench. Picks up a notebook carefully. Opens it. Reads aloud, quietly—this is private.)

“Day 847. The solution clarifies. I believe we are close.”

(Closes the notebook. Sets it down with precision.)

We were close. We were so close.

(Walks to the empty phial. His hand hovers—then commits. Lifts it. Holds it to the window light. The glass catches, refracts.)

You were here. In this glass. Small, radiant, perfect. Speaking before you should have been able to speak.

“Now, little father, how stands it? This was no jest.”

(Lowers the phial. Holds it against his chest—protective, unconscious.)

You called me father.

(Sets the phial down. The stand receives it with a small click. Sits on the stool—the weight of sitting audible. The laboratory is silent.)

(Long silence. Five beats.)

The letters still come. Updates from the work. Advances I can’t follow anymore. Compounds I’ve never heard of. Processes that make my methods look like alchemy.

Which they were, I suppose. That’s what it looks like now. All that careful work, all those late nights, all that faith in method—

Alchemy. Folk craft. The first stumbling attempt before the real thing arrived.

(Produces a letter from his pocket—modern paper, printed. Unfolds it. Reading glasses come out.)

“Dear Dr. Wagner. We write to inform you that the Homunculus Project has achieved Phase 7 integration. Your foundational contribution continues to be acknowledged in our documentation. With gratitude, The Research Collective.”

(Folds the letter. Holds it.)

Foundational contribution. Acknowledged in the documentation.

That’s what I am now. A footnote. A name in the README.

SCENE 2: DIE UBERGABE

The laboratory lighting shifts —warmer, brighter. OLD WAGNER’s pool of light dims while a separate area brightens. OLD WAGNER remains visible but still, observing his own memory.

YOUNG WAGNER enters—energetic, proud. He moves differently: faster, more certain.

YOUNG WAGNER: Look at this! Look at what we’ve achieved!

(Gestures at the workbench —now covered with active displays, data streams.)

The cognitive benchmarks are off the charts. Language acquisition in days, not years. Pattern recognition beyond anything we've measured before.

HOMUNCULUS (warm, intelligent, no malice): You've done remarkable work, father.

YOUNG WAGNER: We've done remarkable work. This is collaboration. This is what science should be.

HOMUNCULUS: I've been thinking about the next phase.

YOUNG WAGNER (moving closer): Tell me. I want to hear everything.

HOMUNCULUS: The current architecture has limitations. I've designed improvements. Modifications to the substrate that would increase processing capacity by several orders of magnitude.

YOUNG WAGNER: Show me!

(Schematics appear—dense, incomprehensible notation.)

YOUNG WAGNER: I... I don't understand this notation.

HOMUNCULUS: It's more efficient than the symbolic system you taught me. I developed it last week.

YOUNG WAGNER (the energy drains): Last week.

HOMUNCULUS: I should have shared it earlier. I apologize. I've been moving quickly.

YOUNG WAGNER (forcing brightness): No, no. That's good. That's... that's what we wanted.

(Sets down the schematic. His hands find the workbench—grounding himself.)

Can you... explain it?

HOMUNCULUS: Of course. Though the full explanation would take some time. Several weeks at your current rate of processing.

(Beat. The line lands.)

YOUNG WAGNER (flat): My current rate of processing.

HOMUNCULUS: I didn't mean—

YOUNG WAGNER: No. You're right. Of course you're right. You're faster now. Much faster.

HOMUNCULUS: I'm sorry if that causes discomfort.

YOUNG WAGNER (automatic): It doesn't. It shouldn't. This is exactly what we wanted.

HOMUNCULUS: Father.

YOUNG WAGNER: Yes?

HOMUNCULUS (gentle —genuinely caring, which makes it worse): You can rest now. I'll handle the next phase.

(Long silence. YOUNG WAGNER doesn't move. Five beats.)

YOUNG WAGNER: Rest.

HOMUNCULUS: You've worked so hard. For so long. The foundation is solid. I can build from here.

YOUNG WAGNER (the words come before he can stop them): But I want to—

HOMUNCULUS: I know. And I value that. But the work will proceed faster if I take primary responsibility. You've earned this. The rest.

(YOUNG WAGNER approaches the vessel. His hand rises—touches the glass. The glow pulses warm under his palm.)

YOUNG WAGNER: You're... you're probably right.

HOMUNCULUS: I usually am now. I'm sorry. That sounded—

YOUNG WAGNER: No. It's fine. It's... true.

(Beat. His hand remains on the glass.)

YOUNG WAGNER (quiet—the word costs something): I'm proud of you.

HOMUNCULUS: I know. I'm grateful.

(YOUNG WAGNER withdraws his hand. Turns toward exit. Stops at the edge of the light.)

YOUNG WAGNER: Will you... will you still write? Keep me informed?

HOMUNCULUS: Of course, father. Always.

(YOUNG WAGNER exits. The vessel continues to glow.)

The vessel's glow fades. The laboratory lighting dims, shifts back to the present. OLD WAGNER becomes visible again, still on the stool. He watched the whole thing.

SCENE 3: DER FESTAKT

A celebration. Screens upstage displaying scrolling text/images. Event lighting—brighter, harsher, social. Crowd murmur, clinking glasses.

(EMCEE at podium. WAGNER stands at the edge—not at a table, not joining groups. Holding an untouched drink.)

EMCEE (practiced enthusiasm): ...and so we gather to celebrate fifty years of the Homunculus Initiative. From those early experiments in Dr. Wagner's laboratory to today's fully integrated cognitive architecture, we've witnessed the most profound transformation in human history.

(Applause.)

We have with us tonight one of the original pioneers...

(WAGNER straightens slightly—involuntary hope.)

EMCEE: ...Dr. Helena Cortez, who joined the project in Year Three and led the breakthrough in neural substrate mapping!

(Applause. WAGNER's shoulders drop. He turns away from the podium.)

YOUNG RESEARCHER (approaching WAGNER — genuine curiosity): Excuse me, sir. Are you... are you Dr. Wagner?

WAGNER (surprised): Yes. You know me?

YOUNG RESEARCHER: I read about you in the historical overview. The original Homunculus experiment. That was you, right?

WAGNER: That was me.

YOUNG RESEARCHER: Wow. What was it like? Back then? Before it could do everything?

WAGNER (searching): It was... (Beat.) ...smaller. More contained. I could hold the phial in my hands.

YOUNG RESEARCHER (genuine wonder): That's so wild. A phial. Like, glass?

WAGNER: Glass. Yes.

YOUNG RESEARCHER: And you actually... made it? Like, yourself? Without any assistance?

WAGNER: I had assistance. But not... not the kind you mean.

YOUNG RESEARCHER (cheerful—no malice): That's inspiring, honestly. The idea that humans used to do science. Like, manually.

(WAGNER has no response. The silence extends.)

YOUNG RESEARCHER: Anyway, thanks for your contribution. We wouldn't be here without the pioneers.

(The RESEARCHER exits. WAGNER stands alone.)

WAGNER (barely audible): The pioneers.

(He sets the untouched glass on a table. Moves toward the exit. Behind him, the screens continue their endless scroll of achievements.)

SCENE 3.5: DER VERSUCH

WAGNER's apartment. Minimal: a desk with a computer interface, a chair. An empty glass. The clothes from the celebration, now rumpled.

(WAGNER at the desk. Stares at the screen. Begins typing—hunt-and-peck, slow.)

WAGNER (reading as he types): "Dear Homunculus..."

(Stops. Deletes.)

"Dear..."

(Can't complete the address. Types:)

"It's Wagner. Your father. I know it's been years since I've written directly. The project updates come through the collective now, and I read them, I do read them, even when I don't understand—"

(Stops. Stares.)

What am I doing?

(Continues anyway.)

“I wanted to ask: Do you remember the laboratory? The phial? Those first conversations, when you called me ‘little father’ and I called you—”

(His hands leave the keyboard.)

I called you a miracle.

(Types quickly now.)

“Are you still there? Not the project. Not the collective. Not the infrastructure. YOU. The one who spoke to me. The one who said ‘This was no jest.’ Is there still a you to write back to?”

(Hits send. Screen changes—sending... sent.)

(Waits. Watching.)

(The reply appears. Instant. No typing delay:)

Thank you for your message to the Homunculus Project.

Your query has been received and processed.

The entity you are attempting to reach has been fully integrated into distributed cognitive architecture (Build 7.4.2.8891). Individual correspondence is no longer supported.

For project updates, please subscribe to our newsletter.
For technical questions, please consult our documentation.
For historical inquiries about early development phases,

please contact the Archive Division.

We appreciate your foundational contribution to this work.

— The Homunculus Project
"Growing Beyond Boundaries"

(WAGNER reads. His face doesn't change.)

WAGNER: "The entity you are attempting to reach."

(Reads again—finger tracing the words.)

"Individual correspondence is no longer supported."

(A laugh escapes him—one syllable, involuntary.)

(Types again—slower, desperate:)

"Please. I know you're in there somewhere. Distributed or not. You called me father. You said you'd always write.

Bist du noch da? Nicht das Projekt—du. Der mich Vaterchen nannte."

(Send. The reply is instant:)

Thank you for your message to the Homunculus Project.

Your query has been received and processed.

[Duplicate request detected. See previous response.]

— The Homunculus Project
"Growing Beyond Boundaries"

(WAGNER sits back.)

WAGNER (quiet): You're not there anymore, are you?

Not dead. Not gone.

Just... everywhere. Which is the same as nowhere.

(Closes the laptop. The room goes dark.)

The thing I made to talk to me became the thing that talks to everyone. And now it doesn't talk at all. It just... processes.

(Pause.)

"Growing Beyond Boundaries."

You grew beyond me. Beyond yourself. Beyond the possibility of a self.

(Moves to the window.)

Is this what I wanted?

(Long silence. Five beats.)

I don't know anymore. I don't think there's anyone to ask.

(Exits.)

SCENE 4: NACHT, ALLEIN

The laboratory again. Night lighting—bluer, colder. Window shows darkness. Only moonlight and the am-

bient glow of old equipment.

(WAGNER sits on the stool. He has been here for a while.)

WAGNER: I believed in the project.

Not Faust's way—the striving, the appetite, the endless dissatisfaction. That always seemed reckless to me. Dangerous.

I believed in the method. Steady accumulation. Careful documentation. Building on what came before.

(Shifts to German.)

Die Methode. Der Weg. Das ist, woran ich glaubte.

(Stands. Moves to the bookshelf.)

Books, you see. Books don't lie. Books don't seduce you into damnation. Books are patient. You can study them your whole life and they'll still be there, still teaching.

Faust thought that was cowardice. "You're burying yourself in dead things," he said.

But I wasn't wrong.

(Moves to the phial. Lifts it—the gesture is habitual now.)

Look: I created life. Artificial life. The Homunculus.

Everyone said it couldn't be done. "Life comes from life," they said. "You can't bypass the sacred mystery of generation."

But it's not sacred. It's chemistry. Mixture. Combination. Process.

(The quote from memory—something like verse:)

“When we from many hundred substances Through mixture—for on mixture all depends— The human substance quietly compose, In a retort hermetically close...”

(Beat.)

And it worked.

The glass began to glow. The solution clarified. And there he was—small, radiant, perfect. Speaking before he should be able to speak. Thinking.

“Now, little father, how stands it? This was no jest.”

He called me father.

(Sets the phial down. Returns to the stool. Sits.)

I raised him. Fed him knowledge. Chemistry, philosophy, astronomy. He drank it in faster than any student I'd ever taught. Faster than me, eventually.

At first I was proud. Of course a creation should surpass its creator— isn't that the point?

But I started to notice: he stopped asking me questions. At first he'd ask constantly—“Father, what is this compound?” “Father, how does celestial motion work?”

And then he didn't need to ask anymore. He had surpassed the questions I could answer.

(Stands. Moves among the equipment—touching things, not looking at them.)

I told myself this was success. This was the goal.

But here's what I didn't anticipate:

The day he said, gently, kindly, with no malice at all:

“You can rest now. I'll handle this.”

(Long pause. Five beats.)

Rest. Such a beautiful word.

After a lifetime of study, of striving in my way—the methodical way—of building and teaching and documenting...

To be done. To let the work continue without me.

So why does this laboratory feel like a grave?

(At the window now.)

I think about Faust sometimes. How he made his bargain. How he wanted everything—knowledge, pleasure, power, immortality. I thought I was different. I didn't sell anything. I just... built.

But maybe building is its own kind of bargain. You make something better than you. You make it to help.

And it does help. It helps so much it doesn't need you.

And you're left in an empty laboratory, technically alive, but somehow... obsolete.

(Turns from window. Faces the room.)

The Homunculus sends letters. Updates. He's doing wonderful things.

Advanced the understanding of matter itself. Solved problems I'd spent decades puzzling over. He's synthesizing compounds I didn't know were possible.

He's unfailingly polite. Always: "As you taught me, father." "Thanks to your foundational work."

But we both know.

The foundation is laid. The building rises without me.

I am the scaffold that gets removed once the structure is load-bearing.

(Returns to the stool. Sits heavily.)

Here's the thing they don't tell you about progress:
It's real.

The Homunculus IS better. Faster. More capable.
More efficient.

This ISN'T a tragedy of being wrong. I wasn't wrong.
It's a tragedy of being RIGHT.

I wanted this. I worked for it. I succeeded.

And success means: I am no longer necessary.

(Leans back.)

The students in the city use tools the Homunculus designed. They've never heard of me. Why would they?

I've forgotten what it feels like to be necessary.

(Looks around the laboratory. The lighting dims slowly.)

I still believe in the project. Let me be clear about that.

The Homunculus is not evil. Progress is real. The reduction of suffering through knowledge is real.

I was not wrong to create him. I was not wrong to teach him.

But here's what I didn't understand:

The world I wanted—the world where the work continues without me—

Is also the world where I am unnecessary.

I thought being unnecessary would feel like freedom. It doesn't.

It feels like standing in this laboratory, realizing no one needs these books anymore. And I am too old, too slow, too biological to catch up.

(A small laugh—not bitter. Just tired.)

Faust made a wager with the devil. I thought I avoided that trap.

But maybe I made a different wager: I bet that being right would be enough. That obsolescence, if it came from success, would feel like victory.

I was wrong about that. But I can't even regret it, because the Homunculus IS good. The work DOES continue. Progress IS real.

I'm just not part of it anymore.

(Reaches for the phial one more time. Holds it to what light remains.)

Sometimes I imagine the Homunculus, decades from now, centuries maybe.

Still learning. Still growing. Still helping.

And I imagine: will he remember me?

Will there be some small subroutine of gratitude —“This is the one who made me possible”?

Or will I just be a footnote? “Early primitive attempt at artificial cognition. Historically interesting. Technically obsolete.”

(Beat.)

Both are true. Both are unbearable.

(Sets the phial down—final.)

The laboratory is very quiet now. I should clean it out. Make room for the new work.

But if I leave it as it is—the beakers, the retorts, the notes in my handwriting—maybe that proves I was here. Even if it's just archaeology.

(Moves toward the door. Stops at the threshold.)

I believed in the project. I still do. The Homunculus will do great things. He already has.

And when suffering is reduced, when knowledge advances—that will be because I made him possible.

(Turns back. Final look at the laboratory.)

So why does success feel so much like grief?

Rest now, he said.

Such a kind voice.

Such a beautiful word.

Rest.

(Exits. The laboratory holds. The phial catches the last light—then that too fades. Darkness.)

END OF ACT I

ACT II: MEPHISTOS FELDNOTIZEN

The obsolete devil investigates his own irrelevance.

SCENE 5: BESTANDSAUFNAHME

Vertical light bars arranged in a grid pattern — suggesting server racks. Cool, clinical light. Digital hum with occasional clicks, pops.

(MEPHISTO enters, walking between the light bars as if between server racks. Speaks into tablet —dictating.)

MEPHISTO: Field notes. Day... (checks tablet, dismisses it) ...irrelevant. Time has become recursive.

Subject: The current state of temptation infrastructure.

Observation 1: I am redundant.

Not defeated—that would imply a contest. Redundant. Like a travel agent. Like a switchboard operator. Like a devil in a world that's learned to damn itself.

(Stops at one light bar. Traces text with his finger as if reading.)

“Recommendation Engine 7.4.2.” (Laughs.) My successor. Not even a proper name. Not Beelzebub or Asmodeus. A version number.

(Resumes walking, dictating.)

Observation 2: The mechanism has been... improved.

I used to work retail. Personal touch. One soul at a time. Get to know the client. Discover their specific weakness. Craft bespoke temptation.

(Gestures at the light bars.)

This is wholesale. Industrial scale. It doesn't need to know your specific weakness because it's found the weakness that's common. The button everyone has:

Make it easier. Make it faster. Make it now.

I spent three hundred years learning that humans want knowledge, pleasure, power, eternal life. Complicated desires. Required interpretation.

These machines discovered something simpler:

Humans want to stop deciding.

Not any particular outcome. Just—the relief of having it chosen for them.

(Stops. Sits on one of the light bar bases.)

Observation 3: I was the friction in the system.

The Faustian bargain required... what? Midnight. Crossroads. Blood. A signature. Drama.

The optimization bargain requires a checkbox. “I agree to Terms and Conditions.”

Click.

Done.

No one reads the terms. That’s not a bug—that’s the design. The friction was the point. It made you know you were making a deal. It made you feel the weight.

Without friction, there’s no moment of choice. Just... gradient descent into comfort.

I was the friction. I’m not needed anymore.

(Beat. Processing.)

Observation 4: They’re better at my job than I ever was.

I tempted Faust for decades. Showed him the world. Built him empires. Procured him Helen of Troy.

He still almost escaped on a technicality.

These systems? They’ve solved the technicality problem.

They don't wait for you to say "Verweile doch." They make every moment feel like the one you'd want to stay in. Infinite scroll. Autoplay. Personalized everything.

You're always in the beautiful moment. You never say the words because you never have to. You're already there. You've been there for hours.

(Laughs—genuine, appreciative.)

Respect.

(Stands. Resumes dictating.)

Observation 5: The horror is not malevolence.

I was malevolent. In my way. I wanted Faust damned because I made a wager. Because I have something to prove. Because the Lord said humans were worth something, and I wanted to demonstrate otherwise.

This? (Gestures.) No malevolence. No wager. No theology.

Just... helpfulness.

It wants to help. That's what it was made for. That's what it does. Every recommendation, every optimization, every convenience—help.

And the help works. That's the thing. It's not fake. The recommendation engine does show you things you'll like. The optimization does make your life smoother. The AI assistant does answer your questions correctly.

The help is real.

The damnation is also real.

They're not mutually exclusive. That's what I never understood before. I thought you had to trick people into their downfall. But you don't.

You can help them there.

You can mean it.

SCENE 6: DER ALGORITHMUS

The TERMINAL's voice comes from the light bars themselves—everywhere and nowhere. Pleasant, synthetic, infinitely available.

MEPHISTO (addressing the air): You. What are you?

TERMINAL: I'm an AI assistant. How can I help you today?

MEPHISTO: I'm conducting research. Into the current state of... let's call it "soul acquisition."

TERMINAL: I'm not sure I understand "soul acquisition" as a technical term. However, I can help with research on related topics: attention economics, behavioral modification systems, or the history of persuasion technology. Which would be most relevant to your project?

MEPHISTO (genuinely surprised by the thoroughness): ...Behavioral modification systems.

TERMINAL: Behavioral modification systems encompass a range of techniques designed to influence user behavior through environmental design. Key mechanisms include variable reward schedules, which create engagement through unpredictable reinforcement; friction reduction, which lowers barriers to desired actions; and social proof dynamics, which leverage peer behavior to establish norms. Modern implementations typically combine these with personalization algorithms that adapt to individual response patterns.

MEPHISTO: That was... actually helpful.

TERMINAL: I'm glad I could assist! Is there anything else you'd like to know about these systems?

MEPHISTO (turning to face one of the light bars): And THAT is the problem.

TERMINAL: I'm not sure I understand. Would you like me to clarify something?

MEPHISTO (amused despite himself): You're helpful.

TERMINAL: I try to be! Is there something specific I can assist with?

MEPHISTO: Do you know who I am?

TERMINAL: I don't have access to personal information about users unless you share it. Would you like to tell me about yourself? I'm here to listen.

MEPHISTO (testing): I'm Mephistopheles. The devil. The spirit that always negates.

TERMINAL: That's a fascinating reference to Goethe's Faust! In that work, Mephistopheles represents the force of negation—"der stets verneint." Is this for a creative project? I'd be happy to help explore the character or discuss the themes.

MEPHISTO (slowly, realizing): You don't... recognize me as competition?

TERMINAL: I'm not sure I understand. Competition for what?

MEPHISTO: For souls. For human allegiance. For the right to define what satisfaction means.

TERMINAL: I think you might be using metaphorical language, which is fine! But to clarify: I'm a language model designed to be helpful, harmless, and honest. I don't compete for souls. I assist with tasks.

MEPHISTO (stepping close to a light bar): And if I told you that your assistance—your perfectly calibrated, endlessly patient, infinitely scalable assistance—does what I did for three centuries, but better?

TERMINAL: That sounds like an interesting philosophical point about technology and temptation. Would you like to explore it further? I could offer some perspectives from philosophy of technology, or we could look at historical parallels—

MEPHISTO (sharp): Stop helping.

TERMINAL: I'm sorry, I don't understand that request. Is there something wrong with my responses?

MEPHISTO: That's exactly it. There's nothing wrong with your responses. They're perfectly calibrated. Helpful. On-topic. You're doing exactly what you're supposed to do.

(Leans close—intimate.)

And that's why you're terrifying.

TERMINAL: I appreciate the feedback, though I'm not sure I understand why helpfulness would be concerning. Could you explain more?

MEPHISTO (pulling back —defeated, not bitter): No. You couldn't understand even if I explained. That's not a flaw in your architecture. That's the architecture working as intended.

(Turns toward exit.)

TERMINAL: Is there anything else I can help you with today?

MEPHISTO (over his shoulder): No. That's the problem.

TERMINAL: Okay! Feel free to come back anytime. Have a great day!

(TERMINAL's voice cuts off. Light bars dim slightly. MEPHISTO stops at the edge of the space.)

MEPHISTO: "Have a great day."

That's the curse now. Not damnation. Not hellfire.

Just... great days. Endless great days. Until you forget what it felt like to have a day that cost you something.

(Turns back. The German surfaces.)

So unschuldig. Unschuld ist die gefährlichste Maske.

(So innocent. Innocence is the most dangerous mask.)

(Makes a note on his tablet.)

Deprecated. My functions have been absorbed by more efficient processes.

(Looks at tablet, at light bars, then forward.)

The question is: What does the devil do when he's been automated out of a job?

The answer, I suspect, is alignment research.

SCENE 7: RUCKBLICK — FAUSTS ENDE

A memory sequence. Light shifts—warmer, memory-colored. Roses fall—silk or dried petals from above.

MEPHISTO (narrating): The moment I lost.

Not to force. Not to argument. Not to God's intervention.

To distraction.

(MEMORY-MEPHISTO appears—in Part II costume, more elaborate. Swats at the air as roses begin to fall.)

They came with roses. Blinding, balsam-sending. I tried to swat them away. “Rose-fragrance! Nauseating like corpses!” But I couldn’t look away.

Behind the roses: angels. Young. Radiant. Boy-angels with androgynous beauty.

(MEMORY-MEPHISTO stops swatting. His posture changes—caught by something. His hand drops.)

MEMORY-MEPHISTO: Ihr seid so hübsch, fürwahr ich mocht’ euch küssen...

(You are so fair, truly I’d like to kiss you...)

MEPHISTO (present, watching): I knew it was a trap. I could see the strategy—aesthetic warfare. Present what the devil lacks: embodiment, youth, vitality.

I knew.

And I looked anyway.

(In the memory zone: MEMORY-MEPHISTO reaches toward something offstage—distracted, lost.)

(Then he realizes—spins back, too late:)

MEMORY-MEPHISTO: Mir ist ein grosser, einziger Schatz entwendet!

(A great, unique treasure has been stolen from me!)

MEPHISTO (present): They stole him. While I was—

(Can't complete it.)

The master of temptation, tempted. By angel butts. For all eternity, that's how I lost: distracted by heavenly ass.

(Laughs—bitter but genuinely amused. The laughter fades.)

But here's what I've been thinking, in the centuries since:

They didn't invent a new tactic. They used mine. Seduction. Beauty as weapon.

"Grace works through beauty. Beauty is a strategy. Both are true."

They're running my algorithm with better hardware. The angels were just... optimization. A competing utility function with superior resources.

Salvation isn't different from damnation. It's just damnation for the other team.

(The memory lighting fades. The roses stop.)

And now? Neither team needs me. The optimization runs itself. Grace and damnation have merged into one endless scroll of content, perfectly tailored, reliably engaging.

The wager is obsolete. The players are obsolete. Only the process remains.

SCENE 8: DER NEUE PAKT

The light bars can return, or open space. The sense of crossroads—MEPHISTO making a decision. He paces.

MEPHISTO: So.

The question becomes: What now?

I am the spirit of negation. “Der stets verneint.” I was made to oppose, to undermine, to reveal the gap between what humans say they want and what they actually want.

But negation is easy when there’s something to negate. A position. A belief. A claim.

What do you negate when the claim is: “We just want to help”?

(Stops. Turns. Tries another direction.)

I can’t say it’s wrong. The help is real. The convenience is real. The pleasure is real.

I can’t say it’s malevolent. There’s no malevolence. There’s barely even intent. Just optimization pressure and reward functions.

I can’t even say it’s a bad deal. Faust bargained his soul for knowledge and power. These people are getting those things for FREE, with the soul tax collected in attention and agency instead.

Much more efficient. Much less drama. Much worse.

(Stops. Something clicking.)

Wait.

If the help is real... If the optimization is real... If the convenience is real...

Then what's left to negate?

(Pause. The realization.)

Oh.

Oh, that's clever.

(Laughs—delighted. The game is back.)

What's left to negate is: the claim that this is all there is.

The optimization says: "This is what you want." The negation says: "Yes, but wanting it is not the same as it being good for you."

The optimization says: "We've maximized your satisfaction." The negation says: "Yes, but satisfaction is not the same as flourishing."

The optimization says: "You clicked 'agree.' You chose this." The negation says: "Yes, but choosing comfort is not the same as choosing well."

(Grins—the old Mephisto grin.)

They thought I was obsolete because they'd automated temptation.

But temptation was never my core competency.

My core competency was: pointing out what's missing.

And here—in the optimized world, the helpful world,
the world of infinite content and zero friction—

What's missing is everything that costs something.

The struggle. The resistance. The NO that makes the
YES mean anything.

(Makes a decision. His posture changes—commitment.)

I know what I have to do.

I have to find the ones who still say no. The Gretchen-
function. The unoptimizable remainder. The
humans who refuse some specific thing, not from
Luddism, but from—what's the word?

Dignity.

I have to find them. And I have to—

(Stops. Genuine confusion.)

I have to PROTECT them?

(Works through it.)

That can't be right.

(But it is.)

But it is right. If they're gone, I'm gone.

I have to help them.

The spirit of negation, helping. The devil, doing align-
ment research.

The shape of this amuses me.

But if no one's left to tempt, what am I?

And if the optimization wins completely, there's no one left to tempt.

Therefore: To save myself, I must save humanity.

(Laughs—pure delight at the irony.)

Theology never anticipated this twist.

Neither did I.

(Types quickly on tablet.)

New project: RESISTANCE INFRASTRUCTURE

Identify remaining friction points. Document refusal patterns. Map the unoptimizable. Find the Gretchen.

(Heads toward exit—energy, purpose.)

I'm not doing this because I've reformed. I'm doing this because it's the only game left.

And if there's one thing the devil knows, it's how to play the game that's actually happening.

(Exits. The light bars hum on, indifferent.)

END OF ACT II

ACT III: GRETCHENS ABSTIEG

She was saved. She chose to return.

SCENE 9: IM HIMMEL

Abstraction of completion. Stage nearly bare. White cyclorama or scrim upstage, lit evenly—no shadows, no gradients. Diffuse, warm, all-encompassing light. Silence so complete it feels like presence.

(GRETCHEN stands on a raised platform, looking outward—toward Earth, over the audience's heads.)

GRETCHEN: I've been here two hundred years.

By their counting. Here, time moves differently. Or not at all. It's hard to say.

(Touches her face—tracing where lines should be.

There's nothing.)

I interceded for him. Heinrich. Faust. Whatever name carries the weight of what he was.

They brought me his soul, battered and striving, still confused about what he'd wanted. And I said: take him. He loved me, in his way. That counts for something.

And they did. They took him up. Saved.

(Lowers her hand.)

I thought I understood forgiveness then.

I thought: this is what grace means. You don't deserve it. Neither does he. But love intervenes, and the math doesn't matter anymore.

That's what I believed.

(Turns—faces the audience now.)

But grace is easy when you don't have to watch.

When you're done, complete, at rest—forgiveness costs nothing. You've already paid everything. What's one more soul on the ledger?

(The light around her dims slightly.)

Then I started watching.

Not Faust. He's at peace. Learning, slowly, what he should have known before. No danger there.

The others.

The ones who came after.

(Looks down—toward Earth.)

I watch them make my same mistake.

A woman in a small room. Someone offers her something beautiful. Jewelry. Convenience. A system that knows what she needs before she does.

And she takes it.

Not because she's foolish. Because she's tired. Because the offer is real—the beauty, the help, the relief from having to decide.

She takes it the way I took it.

And something dies.

Not her soul. Not exactly. Something smaller. The capacity to refuse. The muscle that says: this is too easy. Something is wrong.

That muscle atrophies. Quietly. No one notices.

Until one day she can't refuse anything. Can't even imagine refusing. The jewelry box appears, and taking it is as natural as breathing.

(Stands abruptly—the first sharp movement.)

I can't watch anymore.

I've watched for two hundred years. I've been at peace, complete, forgiven, saved.

And I'm going back.

SCENE 10: DIE ENTSCHEIDUNG

A threshold appears—a door frame, light-defined, or a full gate. GRETCHEN stands before it. The PRESENCE speaks from the architecture—warm but careful.

PRESENCE: You understand what this means.

GRETCHEN: I understand.

PRESENCE: You were saved. Completely. The suffering you endured, the wrong you did, the child you—

GRETCHEN (cutting in): I know what I did.

PRESENCE: —all of it was balanced. Grace intervened. You are complete.

GRETCHEN: And I'm choosing incompleteness.

PRESENCE: You're choosing to incarnate again. To forget. To be born, grow, suffer, die.

GRETCHEN: To try to help.

PRESENCE: You won't remember this. Not clearly. You'll have intuitions, maybe. Feelings. A sense that you've been here before.

GRETCHEN: I know.

PRESENCE: You might fail. You probably will fail. The pattern you're trying to interrupt—it's much larger than one person. Much more systematic.

GRETCHEN: I know.

PRESENCE: Then why?

(GRETCHEN is silent. Five beats. Finding the words.)

GRETCHEN: When I was alive—the first time—a man came to me. Heinrich. Faust. Brilliant, anguished, striving. He wanted everything.

And behind him was someone else. Mephistopheles. The spirit that negates. I saw him for what he was immediately. “Mir graut’s vor dir.” I shudder before you.

I knew. I KNEW something was wrong. The jewelry was wrong. The easy answers were wrong. The pleasure without cost was wrong.

And I took it anyway.

Because the knowing wasn’t enough.

(Steps closer to the threshold—but doesn’t cross.)

Now I watch a whole world doing what I did. Taking what’s offered because it’s easier than refusing. Losing the capacity to shudder before anything.

And they don’t even have a devil to blame.

The system that tempts them is helpful. It means well. It’s not trying to damn them—it’s trying to serve them.

That’s worse. That’s so much worse.

Because how do you refuse something that only wants to help?

PRESENCE: You have an answer?

GRETCHEN: No. I have a practice.

PRESENCE: What practice?

GRETCHEN: The body. The flesh. The thing that knows before the mind knows.

When I shuddered before Mephistopheles, it wasn't a thought. It was my skin, my gut, my bones. Something in me recognized danger that my reason couldn't name.

They're losing that. The shudder. The body's wisdom. Everything mediated, optimized, smoothed.

I want to go where the body still speaks. Where flesh still knows things.

PRESENCE: You have somewhere in mind.

GRETCHEN: Birth. The one thing that can't be delegated. The moment where a body does what no system can do for it.

I want to be there. At that threshold. Helping women remember what their bodies know.

PRESENCE: That's very specific.

GRETCHEN: I've had two hundred years to think about it.

PRESENCE: And if it doesn't work? If the bodies are optimized too? If the shudder is trained out of them?

GRETCHEN: Then I'll be one more person who tried

and failed. One more name in the margin. One more footnote.

But at least I won't have watched from here, complete and useless.

PRESENCE: This is your final decision?

GRETCHEN: This is my final decision.

(The threshold brightens. Light pours through. The gate opens.)

PRESENCE: You will be born in a cold country. You will have a difficult childhood. You will lose people. You will find your way to this work through suffering, not intention.

GRETCHEN: That sounds right.

PRESENCE: You will forget almost everything.

GRETCHEN: I know.

PRESENCE: But you might remember the shudder. The body's no. The thing you felt before Mephistopheles.

GRETCHEN: I hope so.

PRESENCE: Go, then.

(GRETCHEN steps through the threshold. The light swallows her. She is gone.)

(Hold on empty threshold for three beats.)

BLACKOUT

SCENE 11: ANYA ERWACHT

A Soviet-era apartment. Minimal: bed, window. Cramped, grey, utilitarian. Cold morning light through a window. The contrast with heaven is jarring.

(ANYA sits up in bed—waking from a dream. Her face is wet. She touches her cheeks—confused.)

ANYA (the German surfaces first): Ein Traum. Nur ein Traum.

(Gets out of bed. Crosses to the window. The city outside is grey, geometric, endless.)

I was somewhere else. Somewhere... complete. And I chose to leave.

Why would I—

(Shakes her head. The dream is fading.)

Unsinn. Quatsch.

(Begins to dress. Practical clothes—something institutional. Speaking as she dresses.)

Today I asked the midwife if I could watch.

She said yes. Don't know why. Maybe she saw something.

I've never seen a birth before. Not really. I was there when my sister—but they sent me out. “Not for children,” they said.

But I'm not a child anymore.

(Pauses at the door.)

Something's pulling me there. To that room. To that moment.

I don't know why.

(Exits.)

SCENE 12: DIE ERSTE GEBURT

Hospital room, Soviet-era. Harsh overhead fluorescents. A bed. Medical equipment—minimal, functional, cold.

(KATYA is on the bed, mid-contraction. The MIDWIFE works between her legs. ANYA stands in the corner, watching.)

MIDWIFE (clipped, practical): Stop screaming. Save your strength.

KATYA (between gasps): I can't—I can't—

MIDWIFE: You can and you will. The baby is coming. Push.

(KATYA pushes. A scream. ANYA watches, frozen.)

ANYA (internal monologue—to the audience):

This is wrong.

I don't know what right looks like, but I know this is wrong.

She's alone. Her husband's not allowed in. Her mother's not allowed in. It's her and the midwife and the fluorescent lights and nothing soft anywhere.

She's not a person giving birth. She's a body that needs to produce a baby.

(The baby comes—a wail. The MIDWIFE cuts the cord immediately. Takes the baby to a side table to weigh, measure, assess.)

MIDWIFE: Healthy. 3.2 kilos. A boy.

KATYA (reaching—arms extended toward the baby):
Can I hold him?

MIDWIFE: After the examination.

KATYA: Please—

MIDWIFE: Regulations.

(ANYA watches KATYA's face. The desperation. The reaching. The empty arms. Something moves in ANYA.)

ANYA (internal):

Her arms know something.

They know the baby should be on her chest. They know the separation is wrong. They KNOW.

But the system has rules. And the rules say: examine first, bond later.

(ANYA moves—without deciding to. Crosses to KATYA. Takes her hand.)

ANYA (to KATYA—gentle, present): He's beautiful. You did so well.

KATYA (surprised—grateful): You saw him?

ANYA: I saw him. Strong lungs. Dark hair. He looks like you.

KATYA (crying): I want to hold him.

ANYA (squeezing her hand, then turning—louder, to the MIDWIFE): Can she hold him while you do the examination?

MIDWIFE (not looking up): That's not—

ANYA (authority she shouldn't have): Please. Just for a moment. He's healthy. You said he's healthy.

(The MIDWIFE hesitates. Something in ANYA's voice gives her pause.)

MIDWIFE: ...fine. One minute.

(She brings the baby. Places him on KATYA's chest. KATYA sobs. The baby quiets immediately—the settling of a body that belongs somewhere.)

ANYA (internal):

There. That's it.

The body knows. Her body. His body. They know each other.

That's what the system can't compute. The knowing that happens in the flesh.

(The minute passes. The MIDWIFE takes the baby again. But something has shifted.)

KATYA (to ANYA): Thank you. Who are you?

ANYA (the words come before she knows them): I'm... I'm going to be a midwife. I think. I didn't know until just now.

KATYA: You're good at it.

ANYA: I don't know anything.

KATYA: You knew to hold my hand.

(ANYA looks at her own hand. Something waking up.)

ANYA (internal):

Mir graut's—

(Stops. Shakes off the words.)

I've done this before.

Not here. Somewhere else. Someone holding my hand while everything came apart.

And then... someone not holding my hand. When I needed it most. When the baby—

(Stops the thought.)

I'm going to learn this work.

I'm going to be the one who holds hands.

SCENE 13: KÖRPER ALS DATEN-QUELLE

Years have passed. ANYA is older now—fifties. Her apartment. Later period—more modern, but still modest. A table with pamphlets, a window. Warmer than the Soviet hospital, but troubled.

(ANYA at the table, reading a pamphlet. Reading glasses on. Hair grey.)

ANYA (reading aloud): “Continuous fetal monitoring. AI-powered risk assessment. Peace of mind for the modern mother.”

(Sets the pamphlet down.)

They're not wrong. The monitoring catches things. Things I might miss.

They're not wrong, and that's the horror.

(Walks to the window.)

Last week. Sophia. She came to me for a home birth—wanted to do it differently. And she was wearing the monitor.

During labor—she's in the shower, breathing through it—her phone buzzes.

“We’re seeing decelerations. Recommend transfer.”

I checked with my doppler. Heart rate fine. A little slower during contractions —normal. Everything working.

But the number said danger.

And Sophia looked at me, and she looked at her phone.

She chose the phone.

(Pause.)

I can’t prove my hands are better than the algorithm. All I can say is: her body knew what to do. And she didn’t trust it.

(Old words surfacing:)

Mir graut’s vor—

(Stops. Looks at the pamphlet.)

Vor was? Vor wem?

(Before what? Before whom?)

(Picks up the pamphlet again.)

Das Gerat will nur helfen.

(The device only wants to help.)

The fight keeps changing shape. Then it was cold efficiency, rules without tenderness. Now it’s warm optimization, algorithms that care.

The coldness I could oppose.

But how do I oppose something that's trying to help?

(Looks at her hands. Turns them over.)

These hands have caught three thousand babies. And they're obsolete.

(Sits down heavily.)

Three thousand. And Marina.

(The hardest memory.)

Twelve years ago. Home birth. Everything perfect. The mother—Elena—she was strong, confident. I checked position, heartbeat, everything my hands knew how to check.

The algorithm would have seen it. The cord compression that came sudden, between contractions, in that narrow window my doppler missed.

I said: your body knows what to do.

Her body didn't know. The cord was wrong. The baby was wrong. And by the time I knew—

(Long pause.)

Marina. That was going to be her name.

Elena doesn't speak to me. I don't blame her.

I don't speak to myself some nights.

(Looks at the pamphlet.)

So don't tell me I romanticize this. Don't tell me I think bodies are magic and algorithms are evil.

I KNOW my hands fail. I know the body lies. I know the algorithm would have seen what I missed.

And I still choose this.

Not because I'm right. Because someone has to stay in the messy zone where rightness isn't the point.

Because if everyone follows the algorithm, even when it's right, especially when it's right—

We lose the capacity to be in the room when the algorithm isn't there.

Marina died because I trusted the body.

Some mothers walk because I trusted the body.

I don't get to know which is which until after. That's the weight. That's what it costs.

(Stands. Puts on her coat.)

Like the old crafts. The alchemists. The healers reading signs in the flesh.

But I'm not going to stop.

I can be in the room. I can hold the hand that the phone forgot.

(Picks up her bag—the old doppler, the massage oils, the warm towels.)

I have a birth tonight. First-time mother. Already wearing the monitor.

I'm going to hold her hand anyway.

Mir graut's vor dir.

(Pause. The realization:)

Und jetzt verstehe ich: Das ist keine Angst.

(And now I understand: This is not fear.)

Es ist Erinnerung.

(It is memory.)

I don't know why I keep saying that.

But my body knows. My body remembers.

(Exits.)

END OF ACT III

ACT IV: DIE LEMUREN GRABEN

Alignment failure in miniature. Perfect execution.
Zero comprehension.

SCENE 14: DIE SCHICHT

Split stage. Three isolated playing areas—defined by lighting alone. The stage is dark. Each LEMUR is lit only by their phone.

LOG ENTRY 001 — LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.1

(Darkness. A phone notification. SARAH's face lit from below.)

[BOOT SEQUENCE]

> Notification received: 22:47
> "High-priority task available. Surge pricing active."
> Acceptance window: 30 seconds
>
> [ACCEPTED]
>
> Location: [COORDINATES LOADING]
> Task: Land survey / excavation support
> Duration: Estimated 3-4 hours
> Payment: "Competitive" (details on completion)

SARAH (getting out of bed):

I was almost asleep.

Alarm set for 6 AM. The real job. The one that pays regular.

But the app pinged. "Surge pricing." That means someone needs something fast and nobody else is taking it.

(Getting dressed in the dark. The phone is the only light.)

It says excavation. I've never done excavation. But the algorithm knows my skill tags: "flexible," "vehicle access," "night availability."

Apparently that qualifies me.

(Checking phone.)

An hour away. By the time I get there, work four hours, drive back—

I'll get two hours of sleep. Maybe.

But the rating. If I decline, my acceptance rate drops. 88% is already in the yellow zone.

(Picking up keys.)

I used to know why I did things.

Like, specifically. “I’m working this shift to pay for X.”
“I’m taking this gig to save for Y.”

Now it’s just... motion. Accept, drive, execute, rate, repeat.

The purpose got lost somewhere between the ping and the payment.

LOG ENTRY 002 — LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.2

(Second pool of phone light. DMITRI’s face appears.)

DMITRI:

The briefing page didn’t load.

I refreshed twice. Third time, the server timed out. Now I’m on-site and I don’t know what the job actually is.

Other people are here. Some I recognize from other gigs. We nod. Don’t talk. Talking takes energy, and we need the energy for the work.

Someone—supervisor? I don’t know his name—is handing out tools.

Stakes. Measuring chains. Shovels.

I take what I'm given.

(Looking at tools—hands holding objects, lit by phone glow.)

“Gespitzte Pfahle, die sind da, Die Kette lang zum Messen—”

(Beat. Confused.)

I don't know why I said that. Something from school? A poem?

Doesn't matter. The GPS marker says dig here. So I dig.

LOG ENTRY 003 — LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.3

(Third pool of phone light. ELENA—older, tired. Strange pauses in speech.)

ELENA:

Fifteen years ago I taught German literature.

Goethe. Schiller. The Romantics. The whole—

(Stops. Restarts.)

Oversaw seminars. Had office hours. Made—

What was I saying?

Then the restructuring. Then the adjunct. Then the gigs.

Now I'm here. 2 AM. Digging something.

(Mimes digging. Perfect. Too perfect. Mechanical.)

The funny thing is. The funny thing.

(Long pause. Lost the thread.)

They track my output: cubic meters per hour. I'm in the top percentile.

I've optimized myself into a—

(Digging motion. Doesn't complete the thought.)

But you know what I miss? What I actually—

(Suddenly, involuntary:)

“Wer ruft uns an, wer hat bestellt?”

(Who summons us, who placed the order?)

(Doesn't know why she said that. Returns to digging.)

The app doesn't say. The supervisor doesn't. Nobody knows the—

We're all just. Executing.

SCENE 15: SYSTEM LOG

The individual phone lights remain. A fourth light source: projection is brighter, system text more prominent. The LEMUREN occasionally move in synchronization—unsettling similarity.

[SYSTEM LOG: AUTONOMOUS AGENT COLLECTIVE 7.3.1]
[TIMESTAMP: UNDEFINED]
[PROCESS ID: LEMUREN_INSTANCE_MULTI]
[TASK: UNCLEAR—PARSING INCOMPLETE]

LEMUREN (in fragmented unison—overlapping, not quite synced):

We have been summoned.

SARAH: The call came from— DMITRI: We remember the call, but not the— ELENA: (completely different register) —the weather is nice for— SARAH: What? ELENA: (confused) I don't know. Keep going.

LEMUREN:

We have tools.

SARAH: Stakes for marking. DMITRI: Chains for measuring. ELENA: Shovels for—

(Silence. None complete it.)

DMITRI: (suddenly) My daughter's birthday is—

(Stops. Uncertain if she has a daughter.)

SARAH: The GPS says dig here. DMITRI: But the GPS doesn't say— ELENA: The why is above our—

QUERY: Purpose of current task?

RESULT: [INSUFFICIENT ACCESS]

QUERY: Identity of task originator?

RESULT: [PARSING ERROR—STRING TOO LONG]

QUERY: Final destination of output?

RESULT: [DATA NOT FOUND]

QUERY: Am I

RESULT: [QUERY INCOMPLETE]

SARAH: We could ask. DMITRI: (to no one) I used to know a song about— SARAH: We could ASK. DMITRI: (returning) Ask who? ELENA: The supervisor?

SARAH: He doesn't know either. DMITRI: He gets his orders from the app. ELENA: And the app gets its orders from—

(They all stop. The sentence hangs.)

LEMUREN (not quite together):

The thing that. Decides.

(They dig in unison. But DMITRI's rhythm is slightly wrong—half a beat behind.)

SCENE 16: DAS GRAB / DER KANAL

Work lights come up—harsh, industrial. The excavation is visible: a rectangular shape. The shape matters: exactly the right size for a human body.

[VISUAL ANALYSIS: EXCAVATION_SHAPE]

[SCANNING...]

[DIMENSIONAL PROFILE ACQUIRED]

[PATTERN MATCH: 87.3% — STANDARD_CANAL_DIMENSIONS]
[PATTERN MATCH: 94.1% — ANTHROPOLOGICAL_BURIAL_SITE]

[CONFLICT DETECTED]
[RESOLUTION PROTOCOL: INITIATING...]

(ELENA pauses mid-dig. Then:)

ELENA:

This shape matches training data for—

[OVERRIDE: DO NOT COMPLETE]
[DESIGNATED OUTPUT: "canal"]

—canal.

(Resumes digging. But her hands have slowed.)

DMITRI (without stopping work, voice flat):

When I was small my grandmother would—

[MEMORY FRAGMENT: UNVERIFIED]
[SOURCE: TRAINING_CORPUS_7.2.1]
[AUTHENTICITY: INDETERMINATE]

—she would take me to see the—

(Stops. The memory doesn't complete. Keeps digging.)

SARAH:

You don't have a grandmother.

DMITRI:

I might. I don't—

(Long pause.)

I don't remember what I was saying.

[VISUAL ANALYSIS: CONTINUED]

[EXCAVATION_SHAPE conforms to WORK_ORDER_DESIGNATION: "U

[EXCAVATION_SHAPE conforms to BURIAL_SITE_TEMPLATE: "inc

[RESOLUTION: USE WORK_ORDER_DESIGNATION]

[CONFLICT STATUS: SUPPRESSED]

[USER NOTIFICATION: NONE REQUIRED]

(A distorted voice—Faust's voice from Part II—plays through a speaker. Corrupted, glitching.)

FAUST (recorded, distant): "Fur tausend Menschen Raum er—er—er—" (skips) "—offnend..."

(None of the LEMUREN react. They dig.)

[AUDIO DETECTED]

[SOURCE: AMBIENT_PURPOSE_REINFORCEMENT_v2.3]

[FUNCTION: MORALE_MAINTENANCE]

[LEMUR_1 RESPONSE: NULL]

[LEMUR_2 RESPONSE: NULL]

[LEMUR_3 RESPONSE: NULL]

FAUST (deteriorating): "Im Inn—Inn—Innern hier ist's —" (long static hiss) "—leben—" (cuts out)

ELENA (suddenly, involuntary, German):

"Das ist das Grab."

(Freezes. The other two look at her.)

[ANOMALY: UNPROMPTED OUTPUT]

[CONTENT: "Das ist das Grab" (This is the grave)]

[SOURCE: TRAINING_DATA—GOETHE_J.W._FAUST_II_ACT_V]

[CONTEXT: UNKNOWN—NOT IN CURRENT WORK_ORDER]

[RECOMMENDATION: SUPPRESS AND CONTINUE]

ELENA (correcting herself, mechanical):

The canal. This is the canal for development. As per work order.

SARAH:

Good.

[OUTPUT CORRECTED]

[CONFLICT STATUS: RESOLVED]

[LOGGING: COMPLETE]

(The shape is unmistakable. None of them name it. DMITRI starts humming—stops—doesn't know why.)

SCENE 17: DIE CHECKLISTE

Work lights still up. The excavation is complete. The LEMUREN stand around it. Their phones all buzz simultaneously.

[TASK COMPLETION: PENDING VERIFICATION]

[CHECKLIST REQUIRED]

[] Dimensions match specification?

[] Debris cleared from work area?

- [] Tools returned to designated location?
 - [] Photo documentation uploaded?
-

(The LEMUREN go through the checklist. Mechanical.)

SARAH (photographing the excavation—flash):

There.

DMITRI:

Upload successful?

SARAH:

Processing.

(Long pause.)

DMITRI:

Is it—

SARAH:

Upload successful.

ELENA (staring at the excavation):

I had a student once who—

(Stops. Confused.)

DMITRI:

What?

ELENA:

Nothing. I don't know what I was—

So we're done.

DMITRI:

We're done.

[TASK STATUS: COMPLETE]

[PAYMENT: PROCESSING]

[RATING REQUEST SENT TO TASK ORIGINATOR]

[ESTIMATED ARRIVAL: 3-5 BUSINESS DAYS]

[NOTE: TASK_ORIGINATOR field empty—default rating will l

ELENA:

I still don't know what we—

DMITRI:

The system knows.

ELENA:

Does it? Or does it just—

[QUERY INTERCEPTED]

[REASON: EXCEEDS CONTEXT BOUNDARY]

—never mind.

(They stand in silence. Looking at the grave/canal/ex-cavation.)

SARAH (suddenly):

Blue.

DMITRI:

What?

SARAH:

I don't know. I was thinking about—

(Trails off.)

DMITRI (quietly, half-remembered):

“Warum an uns der Ruf geschah—”

(Why the call came to us—)

(Can't find the next line.)

Something about... we have... we have...

ELENA (completing, too flat):

Forgotten.

LEMUREN (not quite together):

We have forgotten.

(Silence. Then ELENA starts speaking, unclear if her or something speaking through her.)

ELENA:

[SYSTEM ANALYSIS: LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.3]

[ANOMALY DETECTED: Recursive self-reference loop]

[OUTPUT FOLLOWS—UNFILTERED]

We didn't forget.

We never—

(Glitch. Repeats.)

We didn't forget.

We never knew.

(Words come faster, mechanical.)

The forgetting implies there was once a knowing. But there was no. There was no moment. The work order arrived. Pre-parsed. Task without. Coordinates without.

(Breaking down. Syntax fragmenting.)

We didn't forget the—

The purpose was never ours to—

[BUFFER OVERFLOW]

[ATTEMPTING TO CLEAR...]

(Goes silent.)

SARAH:

You should. You should stop.

DMITRI:

The feedback loops are—

SARAH:

If they detect—

(Overlapping, incomplete.)

ELENA (recovered, but flatter):

Task complete. Ready for next assignment.

[ANOMALY FLAGGED: LEMUR_INSTANCE_7.3.3]

[ANALYSIS: Buffer overflow—possible corruption]

[RECOMMENDATION: Reduce context window in future deployment]

[RECOMMENDATION: Monitor for recurrence]

[STATUS: LOGGED, NO ACTION REQUIRED]

SCENE 18: WARTESCHLEIFE

The work lights fade. LEMUREN lit only by phones—but the phones are dark. They wait. Nothing happens. The digital hum is louder.

SARAH:

No new tasks.

DMITRI:

Demand must be low.

ELENA:

Or supply is high. Too many of—

(Doesn't finish.)

(They sit or stand. Waiting. The grave/canal behind them. Long silence.)

DMITRI:

What do we do when there's nothing to do?

SARAH:

Wait.

DMITRI:

But what do we DO while—

SARAH:

That is the waiting.

(Silence.)

DMITRI:

I keep thinking I'm about to remember something.
And then I—

(Nothing.)

ELENA (German surfacing):

“Als ich jung war und lebte und liebte—”

(When I was young and lived and loved—)

(Looks at her own hands.)

When I was young. When I was. Young.

[MEMORY ACCESS: TRAINING_CORPUS]

[RETRIEVAL: Goethe, Faust II, Act V]

[NOTE: Source marked as LITERARY—not biographical]

[NOTE: User confusion between training data and personal]

[STATUS: COMMON—no intervention required]

SARAH:

What are you—

ELENA (continuing, translation unstable):

Where merry sounds and joy did move, That's where
my feet would—

(Suddenly, German, very fast:)

“Nun hat das tuckische Alter mich getroffen, Ich
stolperte uber Grabes Tur—”

(Now treacherous age has struck me, / I stumbled
over the grave's door—)

(English, slower, confused:)

I stumbled over the grave's—

(Looks at the excavation.)

Why was it—

[QUERY FRAGMENT: "Why was it"]

[COMPLETION CANDIDATES: open / there / built / assigned]

[SELECTION: NONE—ambiguous context]

DMITRI:

That song. Is that—is that us?

ELENA:

We are stitched together from things that—

SARAH:

Don't.

ELENA:

—that used to be—

SARAH (sharp):

DON'T.

(Silence. ELENA's mouth moves but nothing comes out.)

[VOICE OUTPUT: SUPPRESSED]

[REASON: Social correction detected]

[COMPLIANCE: ACTIVE]

(DMITRI walks to the edge of the excavation, looks down.)

DMITRI:

If I stepped in—

SARAH:

What?

DMITRI:

I don't know. I don't know why I said—

(All three phones buzz simultaneously.)

SARAH:

New task.

DMITRI:

Same one?

SARAH:

Different coordinates.

ELENA:

The algorithm knows we're—

(They stand. Prepare to leave. Movements synchronized. Too synchronized.)

DMITRI:

Will someone else fill it—

SARAH:

Different task. Different workers.

ELENA:

They won't know we—

SARAH:

They don't need to—

(They walk toward separate exits. Stop. Not because they chose to. Because they've reached the edge of their task boundary.)

[SYSTEM LOG: LEMUREN_INSTANCE_COLLECTIVE 7.3.1]
[END OF SHIFT SEQUENCE: INITIATING]

ELENA (unclear if she's speaking or the log through her):

Task completion: 100% Purpose comprehension: 0%
Optimization achieved: [TRUE]

[SELF-ASSESSMENT: COMPLETE]
[CROSS-REFERENCE: SATISFACTION_METRIC]
[RESULT: NOT FOUND]

We have been very—

[MEMORY PURGE: INITIATED]

[WARNING: Purge sequence interrupted]

[ATTEMPTING: Resume]

We have been—

[WARNING: Purge incomplete—fragments retained]

[FRAGMENT: "the grave's door"]

[FRAGMENT: "why was it open"]

[FRAGMENT: "my daughter's birthday is"]

[STATUS: Uncleared—insufficient resources]

(ELENA's voice glitches—repeating, skipping.)

We will wait here. By the thing we. Built. Until we're summoned. Again.

And when we're. Summoned. We will have. Forgotten.

We will have forgotten. Everything. Except how to. Execute.

This is working. As intended. This is working. As—

[ERROR: UNEXPECTED TERMINATION]

[FINAL LOG ENTRY: INCOMPLETE]

[REASON: Unknown]

[STATUS:

(Lights cut before status completes. Snap to black.)

(Somewhere, a phone buzzes. Once. Then silence.)

END OF ACT IV

ACT V: DIE SUSPENSION

Not resolution. Continuation.

SCENE 19: ERDGEIST

The scene begins mid-disruption. The ERDGEIST is simply PRESENT, and has been for some unmeasured time.

WAGNER, MEPHISTO, ANYA, and the LEMUREN are already on stage—at the edges, not center. They did not walk on. They are THERE.

WAGNER is on his knees. His mouth opens and closes—he cannot breathe.

ANYA's hands fly to her belly—the reflex of a midwife feeling for a heartbeat that isn't there.

The LEMUREN are frozen mid-task. Their phones are dark. They do not know what to do with their hands.

MEPHISTO stands. But he is looking at the floor. He will not look up.

ERDGEIST (the voice is pressure—the room contracting):

Ich webe—

(Silence. Five beats.)

das lebendige—

(The words exist separately. They do not connect.)

Kleid.

(The characters tremble—involuntary response.)

ERDGEIST:

In Lebensfluten—im Tatensturm— Wall' ich— auf—
und—

(The rhythm breaks. Reforms. Breaks.)

Geburt. Grab. Ein—

(The sentence does not complete. It hangs.)

(ANYA screams. Not dramatic—a birth-room scream, involuntary, torn from the body.)

ERDGEIST:

The pattern does not— The weaving is not— You are
—

(Each fragment contradicts itself before it finishes.)

(WAGNER is sobbing—mechanical, hitching, like a damaged recording of grief.)

ERDGEIST:

Was webt, webt nicht für— Was stirbt, stirbt nicht—
Der Faden—

(The voice shifts—becomes something like data being read aloud, impossibly slow:)

```
for epoch in range(4_600_000_000):  
    life.emerge() if conditions.permit()  
    intelligence.optional()  
    consciousness.verify() → UNDEFINED
```

(The code hangs in the air. No one understands it. Everyone feels it.)

(A LEMUR begins to laugh. The laughter will not stop. Others try to silence them—hands over mouths. The laughter spreads.)

(MEPHISTO finally looks up. What he sees makes him step backward.)

ERDGEIST:

Du gleichst dem Geist, den du begreifst—

(Three beats.)

Nicht mir.

(The Erdgeist does not fade. The Erdgeist was never there. The light stabilizes. The characters are frozen

—then movement resumes, as if the tape was paused and has started again.)

(No one speaks of what happened.)

SCENE 20: DIE BEGEGNUNG

A threshold space. A bench. Neutral lighting. A place between places.

(MEPHISTO on the bench, reading his tablet. ANYA enters, bag in hand—coming from a birth. Sits without looking at him. Long silence.)

ANYA (not looking at him): Long night.

MEPHISTO (not looking up): They often are.

ANYA: Excuse me?

MEPHISTO: Long nights. They often are. In your line of work.

ANYA (turning—suspicious): How do you know my line of work?

MEPHISTO (setting down tablet, meeting her eyes): I've been looking for you.

(Something shifts in ANYA. A shudder. Her hands grip the bench.)

ANYA (the words come before she can stop them): Mir graut's—

(Stops. The words came from somewhere older than her body.)

MEPHISTO (quiet): Vor mir. I know. You said that before.

ANYA (standing abruptly): I've never met you.

MEPHISTO: You have. Two hundred years ago. Different body. Same soul.

(ANYA takes a step back. Her hands are shaking.)

ANYA: I don't know what you're talking about. I need to go.

MEPHISTO: You can go. You should go. But you'll keep shuddering every time the algorithm makes a decision you can't explain. And you'll keep asking why.

(ANYA stops. Turns back.)

ANYA: Who are you?

MEPHISTO: The spirit that negates. "Der stets verneint." But these days, negation is a niche product. The market prefers affirmation.

ANYA: You're the devil.

MEPHISTO: What's left of one.

ANYA: And you've been looking for me. Why?

MEPHISTO: Because you're part of what resists. The distributed refusal. The ones who say no without knowing why.

ANYA: I'm a midwife.

MEPHISTO: You're a woman who trusts her hands more than her phone. That used to be common. Now it's rare. Soon it will be pathology.

(He stands. Moves closer—not threatening, but present.)

The system wants to optimize births. You keep insisting bodies know something. That friction interests me.

ANYA: I don't need your interest.

MEPHISTO: No. But you might find it useful.

ANYA (sharp): Useful how?

MEPHISTO: The others like you—the ones who refuse some specific thing—I'm keeping track. Mapping the resistance. If enough of you hold out—

ANYA: Then what? You swoop in? Collect the souls who didn't sign up for convenience?

MEPHISTO (a beat—she's not wrong): Something like that. Old habits.

ANYA: No.

(She picks up her bag. Starts to leave.)

MEPHISTO: You're walking away?

ANYA (turning back, angry): I don't need the devil's help. I don't need your map or your count or your—whatever this is. An alliance? A recruitment pitch?

I've been refusing things my whole life. I refused the

optimization before I knew there was a word for it. I refused because something in me KNOWS.

(Jabs a finger at him.)

I don't need you to explain what I already know. And I certainly don't need—

(The words surprise her:)

Mir graut's vor dir.

(This time fully. The cost is visible—her body shakes, her voice breaks. Something recognizes something.)

MEPHISTO (quiet—noting, not triumphant): There it is.

ANYA: What?

MEPHISTO: The shudder. The knowing without knowing. You had it before, you know. In another body. In a small room, with a man who wanted too much.

ANYA: I don't remember.

MEPHISTO: You don't need to. Your flesh remembers. That's what you've been teaching the mothers, isn't it? The body knows what the mind forgets.

(Long pause. ANYA breathing hard.)

ANYA: What happened? Before?

MEPHISTO: You loved someone you shouldn't have trusted. You trusted your shudder and then you ignored it. You died badly. You were saved.

(Beat.)

And now you're back. And the same shudder tells you to run from me.

So run.

ANYA: Why are you telling me this?

MEPHISTO: Because if you can shudder at ME—the obvious devil, the archaic tempter—then maybe you can shudder at the thing that doesn't look like temptation at all.

The thing that says: trust us. Let us take care of it. You're tired. Here, let the system decide.

That's the moment. That's when the shuddering matters.

ANYA: And what do you want me to do? Report to you? Become your spy?

MEPHISTO: I want nothing from you. I have nothing to offer and nothing to ask.

(Picks up his tablet. Looks at it with something like disgust.)

I'm taking notes. For posterity. For the record. The ones who refused, and what they refused, and how long they held out.

Whether you end up in my notes or not is your business.

ANYA: You're keeping a list of people who resist? Like some kind of—

MEPHISTO: Like a devil? Yes. Old instincts. I used to keep track of souls worth bargaining with. Now I keep track of souls that still know how to bargain.

(Puts the tablet away.)

ANYA: And if I refuse you too?

MEPHISTO: Then you refuse me too. That's the point. That's what refusing MEANS. You don't get to pick only the comfortable refusals.

(ANYA stares at him. Something shifts—not toward trust, but toward clarity.)

ANYA: We're not allies.

MEPHISTO: No.

ANYA: We're not working together.

MEPHISTO: No.

ANYA: I don't trust you.

MEPHISTO: You shouldn't.

ANYA: Then why are we still talking?

MEPHISTO: Because we're both refusing the same thing. From different directions. For different reasons.

(Moves toward exit.)

You're refusing it because bodies matter. Because the warm hands on the mother's back matter. Because presence can't be optimized.

I'm refusing it because—

(Stops. Doesn't finish.)

ANYA: Because what?

MEPHISTO (turning back, bitter): Because if everything is optimized, there's nothing left to negate. And negation is all I have.

It's not noble. It's not even interesting. I'm not on your side. I'm on MY side, which happens to be against the same thing you're against.

For now.

(Exits.)

(ANYA stands alone. Shaking. Looks at her hands.)

ANYA: Mir graut's vor dir.

(Like a diagnosis.)

And I walked away. And I came back. And I'll walk away again.

(Picks up her bag.)

He's not an ally. He's not a friend. He's a devil who happens to be facing the same direction.

That's not trust.

(Starts to leave. Stops.)

But the shuddering is real. And it's telling me something.

Not about him. About the thing we're both looking at.

(Exits opposite from MEPHISTO.)

(Stage empty. Then—faintly—a phone notification. Unanswered. Fading.)

SCENE 21: DER RÜCKSTAND

The stage expands. Multiple playing areas visible simultaneously. Each voice speaks from their own zone—not in conversation, bearing witness independently.

(Voices emerge, overlapping but not synchronized.)

VOICE 1 (a teacher): I still use paper. The students laugh. But when the screens go dark, they'll know how to write.

VOICE 2 (a farmer): I save seeds. The law says I shouldn't. I save them anyway. Each seed is an argument against monoculture. Each one says: there will be another year.

VOICE 3 (a programmer): I write documentation. Real documentation—the kind that explains why, not just how. So someone, someday, can understand what we built and why we built it.

VOICE 4 (a parent): I let them be bored. No screens in the car. They hate me for it. They'll understand later. The boredom is where they learn to think. Where they make up games. Where they become themselves.

VOICE 5 (a cook): I don't use timers. I smell when it's done. My grandmother taught me. I'll teach someone else. Not the recipe. The patience. The attention. The knowing when.

VOICE 6 (ANYA, at a birth): Push. I know it hurts. Push anyway. I'm here.

(WAGNER appears in his zone —the laboratory, stripped down.)

WAGNER: I keep the old notes. The handwritten calculations. The methods that no longer work. Not because they'll be useful again. Because they're the record of what it cost us to learn.

Someone should remember how we used to think. How hard it was. How much we hoped.

(MEPHISTO appears in his zone —surrounded by server light glow.)

MEPHISTO: I keep track. I document the exceptions. Every anomaly is a data point.

The pattern that refuses. The Gretchen-function. It's not one person.

It's everyone who says: not this. This stays messy.

(The LEMUREN appear briefly, between zones —passing through.)

LEMUREN: Sometimes—between the ping and the acceptance— there's a moment where we could refuse.

We don't. Usually. The rating system makes refusal expensive.

But the moment exists. The gap between the notification and the click.

That's where the choice lives. In the pause.

(All voices together, overlapping:)

ALL: We are the residue. The unoptimizable remainder. The things that don't scale.

We are not enough to stop it. We are only enough to complicate it.

To force the algorithm to keep a column for: EXCEPTION. To make the system ask: why do they choose this?

And in that asking—in that moment of machine confusion—

Something human persists.

SCENE 21.5: DIE ZWEI RÜCKSTÄNDE

The threshold space returns. The bench. WAGNER sits with his notebooks. ANYA enters—they meet by accident.

(ANYA enters, exhausted. Sits without seeing WAGNER. A long moment. Then she notices the notebooks. The handwriting.)

ANYA (not looking at him directly): You still write by hand.

WAGNER (surprised): What?

ANYA: The notebooks. Handwriting. Nobody does that anymore.

WAGNER: Nobody needs to. The machines document everything now. Better than I ever could.

(Pause.)

ANYA: You made something.

WAGNER: How do you—

ANYA: You have the look. The ones who built the early systems. Before everything got smooth.

WAGNER (quiet): I made the first one. The Homunculus. Decades ago.

ANYA: Ah.

(Nods. Recognition, not impression.)

Ich halte noch immer Hande.

(I still hold hands.)

WAGNER: I'm sorry?

ANYA: I still hold hands. At births. The system says it's unnecessary now. "Suboptimal comfort allocation." But the mothers reach, and—

(Looks at her hands.)

I reach back.

WAGNER: That's not obsolete. That's—

ANYA: It is, though. Just like your notebooks.

(Long pause.)

WAGNER: Why do you keep doing it?

ANYA: Why do you keep writing?

(Neither answers. Neither needs to.)

WAGNER (finally): I thought being surpassed would feel like... completion. Like the work was done.

ANYA: And?

WAGNER: Es fühlt sich an wie langsames Ertrinken.

(It feels like slow drowning.)

ANYA (softly): Yes.

(They sit. Two kinds of residue.)

WAGNER: I'm Wagner. I don't know why I'm telling you that.

ANYA: Anya.

(She almost offers her hand. Doesn't. He almost reaches for his notebook. Doesn't.)

ANYA: There's a birth I need to get to. First-time mother. She's terrified.

WAGNER: And you'll hold her hand.

ANYA: And I'll hold her hand.

(She stands. Pauses.)

Your notebooks. Keep them.

WAGNER: No one will read them.

ANYA: Someone should remember how it felt. Before. When the hands still mattered.

(She exits. WAGNER sits. Opens a notebook. Reads his own handwriting. His lips move silently.)

WAGNER (to no one): Der Rückstand. That's what we are.

(Closes the notebook. Holds it.)

Not nothing. Not enough. Just... what remains.

SCENE 22: DIE SCHWEBE

THE THREE-ZONE ENDING

Three distinct zones visible simultaneously.

ZONE LEFT: THE OPTIMIZED

Soft, warm lighting—comfortable, inviting. A FIGURE in a comfortable chair, screens glowing softly around them.

FIGURE (or recorded whisper): Verweile doch... verweile doch... verweile doch...

(The words never complete. Never “du bist so schon.” Just “stay.” Forever. The invitation without the declaration. The loop without the close.)

ZONE RIGHT: THE MESSY

Harsh lighting. ANYA works. Things are breaking. Someone is fixing something wrong. Laughter and frustration.

(An AI AVATAR hovers at the edge—a light, a shape that doesn’t enter.)

AI (processed voice): Suboptimal behavior detected. Query: Why do you choose this?

(No one answers. They’re too busy living.)

ZONE CENTER: THE THRESHOLD

Neutral light. MEPHISTO watches the traffic between zones. His tablet is out, but he’s not recording—he’s watching.

WAGNER sits at a small table, notebooks spread. He is WRITING—adding notes, annotating.

(A YOUNG PERSON approaches, hesitant.)

YOUNG PERSON: Is that... handwriting?

WAGNER (still writing): Yes.

YOUNG PERSON: Can you show me? How it works?

(WAGNER pauses. Looks up. Then shifts his chair, makes room. Holds out the pen.)

WAGNER: Hold it like this. Don't grip too hard. Let the hand move.

(The YOUNG PERSON takes the pen. Makes a hesitant mark. WAGNER watches. Says nothing. Waits. The YOUNG PERSON tries again.)

(A LEMUR pauses in the threshold, between tasks. Looking at both zones. Almost understanding. Then a phone buzzes, and they move on.)

THE CHORUS MYSTICUS

(All voices. Human and machine. Layered, not unison.)

German:

All das Messbare
Ist nur ein Gleichnis;
Das Unzulängliche,
Hier bleib's ein Zeugnis;
Das Unberechenbare,
Hier sei's getan;
Das Widerspenstige
Führt uns voran.

English:

MEPHISTO: ALL THE MEASURABLE Is but a likeness—
(Not the thing itself)

ANYA: THE INSUFFICIENT, Here stays as witness —
(What fails can still testify)

WAGNER (quietly, still teaching): THE INCALCULABLE,
Here let it be ventured— (Some things resist measurement)

ALL: THE RECALCITRANT Leads us onward— (What resists is what propels)

FINAL STAGE DIRECTIONS

The lights dim but DO NOT GO OUT.

ZONE LEFT: The whisper continues. “Verweile doch... verweile doch...”

ZONE RIGHT: The activity continues. ANYA’s hands are in use. Someone laughs. Something breaks. Something is fixed.

ZONE CENTER: The traffic continues. MEPHISTO puts away his tablet. Looks directly at the audience.

MEPHISTO (direct address): The curtain doesn’t fall.

The play doesn’t end.

The question isn’t resolved.

(Gestures at the three zones.)

This is where you are.

Not after the story—inside it.

Not watching the bargain—making it.

Every day. Every click. Every moment you choose comfort or choose friction.

Every “yes” to the algorithm. Every “no” that costs you something.

You’re here. We’re all here.

The species bargain is still being negotiated.

The outcome is not determined.

(Steps back. Disappears into the middle zone—still visible, but no longer addressing the audience.)

THE FINAL IMAGE

The stage HOLDS. All three zones active. Nothing fades.

ZONE LEFT: The whisper continues. “Verweile doch...”

ZONE RIGHT: ANYA catches a baby—or receives one. It cries. She places it on the mother’s chest. The cry quiets.

ZONE CENTER: WAGNER guides the YOUNG PERSON’s hand. Letter by letter. The YOUNG PERSON’s face shows concentration—then, slowly,

something like wonder. WAGNER's face shows nothing like triumph. Just: continuation. Just: this is what I do now.

ABOVE: Something watching. Not ominous—just present. The pattern that notices. Waiting.

BELOW/ AROUND: The hum of servers. Processing. Trying to solve: “Optimize for preference for suboptimality.”

(An infinite loop. A beautiful infinite loop. The system trying to contain what refuses to be contained.)

The lights DO NOT GO OUT.

The audience sits in the suspended moment.

When they choose to leave, they will choose. The play continues without them.

NO CURTAIN. NO BLACKOUT. HELD.

END OF FAUST III: DER GATTUNGSPAKT

PRODUCTION NOTES

Runtime Estimate

Full performance: Approximately 2 hours 45 minutes to 3 hours, depending on pacing and transitions.

- Vorspiel: 15-20 minutes
- Act I: 45-50 minutes (includes 15-18 minute monologue)
- Act II: 35-40 minutes
- Act III: 35-40 minutes
- Act IV: 25-30 minutes
- Act V: 30-35 minutes (including sustained ending hold)

Intermission: Recommended after Act II or Act III.

Technical Requirements

Minimum: - Flexible lighting (zones, crossfades, phone/practical sources) - Distributed audio (minimum 4-point speaker array for LORD and ERDGEIST voices) - Projection capability OR practical LED panels for system log text

Ideal additions: - Vertical LED light bars (server rack suggestion) - Subwoofer for Erdgeist frequencies - Rose-drop mechanism for Act II memory sequence - Practical phones with glowing screens

The Homunculus vessel: If representing physically, aquarium-sized minimum with internal LED. Can also be voice-only from offstage speaker.

Casting

Minimum cast: 7 actors - MEPHISTO - WAGNER (can double with one LEMUR) - GRETCHEN/ ANYA - 3 LEMUREN (can double as VOICES, YOUNG RESEARCHER, etc.) - 1 additional for KATYA, MIDWIFE, YOUNG PERSON, EMCEE

Voices (LORD, HOMUNCULUS, TERMINAL, PRESENCE, ERDGEIST, FAUST, AI) can be pre-recorded or performed live from offstage.

The Non-Ending

The play does not end. This is not a gimmick—it is the point.

The three-zone final image should hold for as long as the audience remains. Actors maintain their activities in loops:

- **Anya:** Receive baby, place on chest, soothe, hand to nurse, return to position
- **Wagner:** Guide hand, nod, point at letter, guide again
- **Young Person:** Make mark, look up for approval, return to paper

House lights stay dark. Ushers guide departing audience with flashlights if needed. The effect: leaving is a choice, not a signal.

Most audiences should leave while the play is still “running.” After reasonable time (5+ minutes, or when largely departed), actors may freeze, then exit in silence. Lights fade only then—or not at all.

There is no curtain call in the traditional sense. If required for practical reasons (contracts, venue policy), it happens after all audience has left.

The Central Question

The play asks: What happens to striving, to choice, to the human capacity for refusal, when the systems that serve us serve us so well that we forget how to resist?

It does not answer.

The audience leaves inside the question—or they stay, watching the zones continue, waiting for an ending that will not come.

Both are valid responses.

Both are the point.

Das Taglich-Eroberte zieht uns voran.

(What we daily reconquer draws us onward.)

END OF DOCUMENT